

Reading the Dice

A player reference for The Ember Age (FFG Star Wars narrative dice)

You rolled. Symbols everywhere. Here is the whole trick: the dice answer **two separate questions**, and you only freeze when you try to make them answer one. Question one — *did it work?* Question two — *what else happened?* Settle them in that order, out loud, and you are done in ten seconds.

Reading a Roll in 10 Seconds

Axis 1 — Did it work? Count **Success** symbols, count **Failure** symbols. Each Failure cancels one Success. If at least one Success is left over, the check succeeds. If Successes and Failures cancel out exactly — or Failures win — the check fails. Ties go to failure. Nothing else on the table can change this answer.

Axis 2 — What else happened? Count **Advantage** symbols, count **Threat** symbols. Each Threat cancels one Advantage. Whatever is left over is a side effect — a perk if Advantage remains, a complication if Threat remains. This currency **never** turns success into failure or failure into success. You can fail brilliantly (failure with Advantage: the lock holds, but you spot the maintenance hatch) or succeed at a price (success with Threat: the door opens, loudly).

The big symbols:

- **Triumph** is a Success *plus* something spectacular. Its built-in Success goes into the Axis 1 tally and can be cancelled by a Failure like any other — but the Triumph *effect* is never cancelled. Even on a check that fails overall, you still spend the Triumph.
- **Despair** is the mirror: it adds one Failure to the Axis 1 tally (cancellable normally), and its *effect* always lands regardless of the roll's outcome. You can succeed and still eat a Despair.
- Triumph and Despair do **not** cancel each other. Both fire.

So every roll lands in one of four quadrants — succeed/fail crossed with perk/complication — plus optional fireworks. Name the quadrant, then spend.

Spending Advantage and Triumph in Combat

These are the standard rulebook options. Announce your spend; the GM narrates it.

COST	EFFECT
1 Advantage	Recover 1 strain (may be chosen more than once).
1 Advantage	Add a boost die to the next allied character's check.
1 Advantage	Notice one important point in the fight — the blast door controls, a weak seam in the armor plating, the catwalk above.
1 Advantage	Activate a weapon quality whose listed cost is 1.
2 Advantage	Perform one immediate free maneuver (cannot exceed the two-maneuver-per-turn limit).
2 Advantage	Add a setback die to a targeted character's next check.
2 Advantage	Activate a weapon quality (2 is the default cost unless the quality says otherwise).
3 Advantage	Negate the target's defensive bonuses (cover, equipment, guarded stance) until the end of the current round.
3 Advantage	Ignore penalizing environmental effects (weather, zero-g, and the like) until the end of your next turn.
3 Advantage	Force the target into a significant drawback — drop a wielded weapon, or (on a damaging hit, with GM agreement) disable a piece of their gear instead of dealing the damage.
Advantage = weapon's Critical rating	On a hit that deals damage past soak, trigger a Critical Injury . Extra activations add +10 each to the Critical roll.
1 Triumph	Any option above, regardless of its Advantage cost.
1 Triumph	Trigger a Critical Injury on a damaging hit, regardless of Critical rating.
1 Triumph	Activate any weapon quality, regardless of its cost.
1 Triumph	Upgrade the difficulty of the target's next check, or upgrade the ability of an ally's next check (yourself included).
1 Triumph	Do something vital and scene-shaping: shoot the blast-door controls, collapse the catwalk, spot the escape route.
2 Triumph	On a damaging hit, destroy one piece of equipment the target is using — blow up their blaster, burn out their shield generator.

***One crit per hit.** A single hit can inflict only **one** Critical Injury, no matter how you pay for it. Every activation after the first — whether bought with Advantage or Triumph — instead adds +10 to that one Critical roll.*

The Mirror: Threat and Despair in Combat

The GM (or you, narrating your own stumble) spends these against the active character.

COST	EFFECT
1 Threat	Suffer 1 strain (may be applied more than once).
1 Threat	Lose the benefit of a prior maneuver (your aim, your guarded stance) until you take it again.
2 Threat	An opponent may take one immediate free maneuver.
2 Threat	Add a boost die to a targeted character's next check, or a setback die to your own or an ally's next check.
3 Threat	Fall prone.
3 Threat	Grant the enemy a significant advantage in the encounter — you shoot out the bridge controls you needed for your own escape.
1 Despair	Your ranged weapon runs out of ammunition for the rest of the encounter.
1 Despair	Your weapon or tool is damaged — it jams, cracks, or degrades a step.
1 Despair	Upgrade the difficulty of an ally's (or your own) next check.
1 Despair	A serious GM complication: the shot hits an ally, the gear breaks at the worst moment, the fallback plan closes.

Advantage Outside Combat

Out of combat, Advantage buys narrative position: information, time, goodwill, or a setup for the next check (usually a boost die to a follow-up, a setback die on the opposition, or a detail the GM confirms). One or two Advantage buys something small; three or more, or a Triumph, buys something the whole scene turns on. **You may suggest any of these to the GM:**

- **Slicing (Computers):** leave no trace in the log; find one extra file you were not looking for; keep the backdoor open for later.
- **Mechanics:** the repair holds longer than it should; finish faster than expected; salvage a usable spare part from the job.
- **Astrogration:** shave hours off the transit; note a landmark worth adding to the rutter; arrive positioned exactly where you wanted.
- **Negotiation:** better price, or a favor thrown in; learn what the other side actually values; leave the door open for future business.
- **Charm / Deception:** the target repeats your version to others; you read what they are hiding; the lie survives one follow-up question.
- **Stealth:** find an exit route as you go; overhear something useful; leave the guards arguing about whether they saw anything at all.

Failed the check but rolled Advantage? Same menu, smaller portions: the attempt did not work, *and* you learned something, kept your cover, or set up the next try.

The Ember Age Spends (Campaign-Specific)

House options for this campaign's subsystems. All of these are proposals, not entitlements — see the etiquette box.

COST	SITUATION	EFFECT
2 Advantage	Any relevant Knowledge check	Surface a lead: the GM names where a related lore fragment might be found — a witness, a rutter page, an unwiped droid.
2 Advantage	Beacon relight, any stage	Ease the next stage: hand a boost die to whichever crewmate tackles it.
1 Advantage	Social check with a faction agent	Glimpse a hairline crack: one hint of the tension running through their faction.
3 Advantage	Cantina or swoop-circuit scene	The rumor network works for you: a courier carries one message or question ahead of you, free.
1 Triumph	Beacon relight, any stage	One stage's failsafes yield early: that stage completes without a further check.
1 Triumph	Reconstruction scene	A secret beyond the Question: the GM reveals something the fragments were never asked about.
1 Threat	Open Force use with witnesses	The crowd's reaction worsens one extra step beyond the normal witness rule.
2 Threat	Astrogation on a decayed lane	Your route leaks: a rival crew or faction learns which corridor you are running.
1 Despair	Reconstruction scene	A corrupted conclusion enters play — and the party believes it.
1 Despair	Beacon relight, any stage	The relight broadcasts wider than intended. Someone you did not invite heard it, and is coming.

Etiquette at the Table

***The player proposes, the GM disposes.** Suggest a spend in plain words — "two Advantage: can I get a free maneuver to duck behind the crates?" — and let the GM shape it. You will rarely be told no; you will often be told "yes, and."*

***Spend promptly.** A decent spend now beats a perfect spend after two minutes of menu-reading. Table momentum is worth more than optimization, and the strain recovery is always there when nothing else sings.*

***Use it or lose it — gracefully.** Unspent Advantage does not bank between rolls. If you shrug, the GM may spend it as scene color on your behalf. That is not a punishment; it is the dice refusing to be boring.*

When in doubt: recover strain, boost a friend, or notice something. Those three answers are never wrong.